

Malaysians 3-11 in head-to-heads, but after heeding coach B. Sumeeth Reddy's advice to "be daring", they stormed through the opening game. The Malaysians fought back to 19-19 in the second, only for the Indians to close out the next two points. Both dropped their racquets, Rankireddy stood in disbelief at the Adidas Arena, and Shetty kissed the Indian badge on his shirt – a moment of 'redemption'.

"When the draw was out, I knew it wasn't going to be easy. We watched videos and analysed the main issues. After beating the Chinese pair (Liang Wei Keng-Wang Chang), the players' confidence went up. It was a lot of motivational talk, getting them ready mentally. I told them that we must get them this time," Malaysian coach Tan Kim Her, credited with pairing up the two shuttlers almost a decade ago, told Sportstar.

Nerves that linger

Bronze was assured, but the chance to go further slipped away in the semifinals. Against China's relatively unknown duo Li Yiu and Bo Yang Chen, opponents they had faced only once before, the Indians faltered 19-21, 21-18, 12-21.

"We were leading well at 11-5. Suddenly, the Chinese were playing freely; they had nothing to lose. Their service game was really good, and our boys were getting confused. Sometimes they were serving low, sometimes playing it up. Moreover, I think our boys started losing patience. They were too eager to finish the point quickly," Tan analysed.

Nerves, especially after gaining the lead, have haunted Rankireddy and Shetty before. It is a recurring subject in the Indian camp.

"Individuals have different ways of dealing with it. Based on my experience from when I used to play, I told them that I would talk to myself. I wouldn't think about finishing. If you keep thinking, 'Okay, we have two more points to go,' you'll be more tense if the opponent starts catching up. They tell me a few ideas on how to deal with this pressure. Sometimes it works,

sometimes it doesn't. But at least we don't hold back when we play. We have to play freely. If you play too safe, chances of losing are high. We must dare to take the risk," Tan said.

Second stint, new methods

Tan, the 53-year-old former doubles player, had left the Indian setup in 2019. He returned five years later, shortly after Mathias Boe stepped down following the Olympic debacle. Reunited with his proteges, Tan was startled by their condition.

"I didn't know that there were so many injuries. That's not where I wanted them physically. I cannot overexert them either because I need their bodies to recover. We began slowly, but we now try to increase the intensity gradually. I even inform them that 'This week, I'm going to do this.'"

In his first stint, Tan's main task was to build trust between two promising youngsters, identifying their height and attacking instincts as natural assets. Now, the approach is different: solution-orientated, with defeats analysed and training tailored to eliminate weaknesses and amplify strengths.

Tournament scheduling, too, is more selective. "When I came back, I



Missed chances: It was Satwik-Chirag's fifth semifinal exit of the year after the India, Singapore, Malaysia and China Opens. PICS: AFP

told them the few major tournaments that were my target for them. One was All England, which was right after Satwik's father passed away, and then Chirag got injured. The other target was the Worlds; now the World Tour Finals is the major event left this year," Tan said.

The pair's world rankings slipped to 18th in May but bounced back into the top 10 after a semifinal finish at the China Open. "They have taken the standard of Indian doubles to a different level. I think people forget that. They never complain, but a lot of people take them for granted. If they were not there, Indian doubles would have been a funny case," said Sumeeth, now overseeing India's women's doubles programme.

Currently ranked sixth in the World Tour standings, with the top eight pairs qualifying for the year-end Finals, Rankireddy and Shetty will next play the Super 500 Hong Kong Open, aiming to consolidate their position.